

COLLAPSE OF THE CONFEDERACY

1865

On the eve of Robert E. Lee's surrender of his army on April 9, 1865, large areas of the southeastern United States were still nominally in Confederate hands. In reality, the situation was in flux, and none of the developments favored the Southern cause.

With the fall of Richmond six days before Lee's surrender, the Confederate government had lost its capital, and President Jefferson Davis had become a fugitive, dependent on those railroads still operated by the Confederacy to stay out of Federal hands. Eleven days before that, Union general William T. Sherman, advancing northward from Savannah through the Carolinas, had successfully rendezvoused at Goldsboro with another Federal force, under John M. Schofield, which was moving inland from the port of Wilmington. The remaining Confederate forces in the area were no match for the combined strength of Sherman and Schofield.

Meanwhile, Union armies were also making progress in Alabama. A cavalry force under James H. Wilson was striking south from the Tennessee border at the same time that troops under Edward Canby were besieging the port of Mobile at the southern end of the state. Mobile finally fell on April 12, just three days after Lee's capitulation; on the same day, Wilson's raiders entered the state capital of Montgomery. For a time, Jefferson Davis refused to accept the reality of the situation, but his remaining commanders soon convinced him that their troops were no longer in a condition to fight. Joseph E. Johnston, leading Confederate forces in the Carolinas, entered negotiations with his adversary, Sherman, on April 17, formally surrendering nine days later. Confederate commanders in Alabama and the Trans-Mississippi Department followed suit shortly after, bringing the war to an end by early June.

